Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

Document version: 1.0.0-beta, April-2026.
Distributed at GitHub
https://github.com/wrwetzel/helix
https://helix.wrwetzel.com
Based on Helix version: 25.07.1.
https://helix-editor.com/
© 2026 Bill Wetzel - Licensed under CC BY 4.0.
https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/

1.1 Definitions

- **file** - the actual data on storage device
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor, not just the selection
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping

1.2 Typographic Conventions

- **`word`** - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- **`WORD`** - whitespace-delimited
- **`Ctrl-c`** - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- **`Alt-c`** - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Metavars **`<regex>`**, **`<file>`** and **`<ch>`** represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the command.
- **`␣c`** is space followed by the character c.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- **`␣`**, **`<minus>`**, and **`<under>`** used for clarity. **`<enter>`**, **`<del>`**, **`<bksp>`**, etc. used for non-printing control characters.

1.3 Launching

- **`helix`**
- **`helix`** `<file>`
- **`helix`** `<file1> <file2> … <filen>`
- **`helix`** `–help`
- **`hx`** `in some distributions or by alias`

1.4 Basics

Editing paradigm: select first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

1.4.1 Example

```
v3wd
        v – enter select mode
        3 – select 3
        w – words
        d – delete
```

1.4.2 Samples

```
       wd – delete word
       xc – change line
```

2.2.2 By Language Server Protocol - Seman

Requires LSP support.

```
       gd – go to definition
       gy – go to type definition
       gr – go to references
       gi – go to implementatio

       ]d – next diagnostic
       [d – prior diagnostic
       ]D – last diagnostic
       [D – first diagnostic
```

2.2.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
   ]f, [f – to next, prior functi
   ]t, [t – to next, prior type d
   ]T, [T – to next, prior test
   ]a, [a – to next, prior arg
   ]c, [c – to next, prior comm
   ]g, [g – to next, prior chang
   ]G, [G – to last, first change

    Alt-e – move to end of pare
    Alt-b – move to start of par
```

2.2.4 By Page

```
    Ctrl-b – page up
    Ctrl-f – page down
    Ctrl-u – half page up
    Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.3 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between ancho
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.3.1 Operations

```
       % – select whole file
   Alt-; – swap anchor and cu
   Alt-: – selection to normal
   Alt-o – expand selection sy
   Alt-i – shrink selection
       ; – collapse selection(s)
```

2.3.2 By TextObjects

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch> – match arou
                  below:
          w / W – word / WO
              p – paragraph
   (, [, ', etc.– specified su
              m –  closest su
              f – function
              t – type or cla
              a – argument/
              c – comment
              T – test
              g – change git
```

2.3.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
    w / W – to start of next wor
    e / E – to end of current wo
```

```
%y – yank entire file
```

1.5 Modes

As used in Helix documentation.

```
  : – command
  i – insert
  v – select or extend
  z – view - change view preserving selection
  g – goto
  m – match
Ctrl-w – window
  ␣ – space
[, ] – unimpaired
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Essentials

```
        u / U – undo / redo change in linear history
Alt-u / Alt-U – move backward / forward in tree history
  :ear / :lat – move backward / forward in history by step count or time span
                (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
   <nn><cmd> – repeat <cmd> <nn> times
         Esc – return to normal mode
```

2.1.1 Quit

Add **!** suffix to force operation.

```
      :wq – write current buffer and quit
:wq <file> – write current buffer to <file> and quit
     :wqa – write all buffer(s) and quit
       :q – quit current buffer, exits if last
```

2.1.2 Files

```
   :o <file> – open <file> in new buffer
   :w <file> – write current buffer to <file>

  :hs <file> – open/create <file> in new horizontal split
  :vs <file> – open/create <file> in new vertical split
        ␣wf – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal split
        ␣wF – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical split
         gf – open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection.

         ␣f – open file picker at LSP workspace root
         ␣F – open file picker at current working directory
         ␣g – open changed file picker
```

2.1.2.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

```
<enter> – open selected in current view
 Ctrl-s – open selected in new horizontal split
 Ctrl-v – open selected in new vertical split
```

2.1.3 Buffers

Add **!** suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

```
   :n – create new scratch buffer
  :bc – close current buffer
 :bca – close all buffers
 :bco – close all but current buffer
  :bn – next buffer
   ␣b – open buffer picker

   ga – go to last accessed/alternate buffer
   gm – go to last modified/alternate buffer
   gn – go to next buffer
```

```
  b / B – to start of current w
      x – current line, extend
      X – extend to line
 Alt-x – shrink to line bound
     ]p – to next paragraph
     [p – to prior paragraph
```

2.3.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
  Alt-o – expand selection to
  Alt-i – shrink syntax tree o
  Alt-p – select previous sibli
  Alt-n – select next sibling n
  Alt-a – select all sibling nod
  Alt-I – select all children no
```

2.3.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
f<ch>, F<ch> – to <ch> inclusiv
t<ch>, T<ch> – to <ch> exclusiv
      Alt-.  – repeat last find
```

2.4 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
     v – toggle select mode
   Esc – return to normal
     ) – cycle primary select
     ( – cycle primary select
Alt-,  – remove primary sele
```

2.5 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one

2.5.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
s<regex> – matches become sel
       S – split on match
  Alt-s – split on newlines
C, Alt-C – add selection below,
```

2.5.2 Operations

```
           & – align on primary cu
Alt-<minus> – merge selections
Alt-<under> – merge consecutive s
         , – remove all except pr
     Alt-, – remove primary sele
     ( / ) – rotate primary back
Alt-( / Alt-) – rotate content back
           K – keep selections mat
       Alt-K – remove selections m
```

2.6 Alter Buffer Content

2.6.1 Insert

```
  i – before selection
  a – after selection
  I – at start of line
  A – at end of line
  o – add line and insert b
```

```
gn – go to next buffer
gp – go to previous buffer
```

2.1.4 Views

Ctrl-w and ␣w are synonymous.

```
␣ws / ␣wv  – split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
␣wns / ␣wnv – split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
␣wq – close current split
␣wo – close all but current split
␣ww – next split

␣wh/j/k/l – move to buffer left / up / down / right
␣wH/J/K/L – swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
␣wt – transpose split
```

2.1.4.1 View Movement

Commands shown with **z** prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

```
Z – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc

zz, zc – align to center
zt – align to top
zb – align to bottom
zm – align to middle horizontally
zj – scroll down
zk – scroll up
```

2.1.5 Help

```
:tutor – open tutorial
␣? – open command palette
```

2.2 Movement

2.2.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right
gh, g| – beginning of line
<nn>g| – column <nn>
gl – end of line
gg – top of file
<nn>G, g<nn>g – line <nn>
ge – bottom of file
gw – two-char labels on words, label to go to word

g.– to last modification in current file
gj – down textual line
gk – up textual line

gs – first non-white-space char
gt – top of screen
gc – middle of screen
gb – bottom of screen
```

```
O – add line and insert a
Esc – end insert (return to
. – repeat last insert
```

2.6.2 Add

```
]␣ – newline below
[␣ – newline above
ms<ch> – add delim <ch> arou
```

2.6.3 Delete

```
d – selection -> yank buf
Alt-d – delete, no save
md<ch> – delete delim <ch> ar
```

2.6.4 Change

```
c – selection -> yank buf
Alt-c – change, no save
= – format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1>
```

2.6.5 Indent Lines

```
> – Indent line(s) contai
< – Undent line(s) conta
```

2.6.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
~ – change case
` – set lowercase
Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.6.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
␣C – Toggle block comme
␣Alt-C – Toggle line commen
```

2.6.8 Increment / Decrement

```
Ctrl-a – increment the select
Ctrl-x – decrement the selec
```

2.6.9 Miscellaneous

```
J – join lines in a selecti
Alt-J – join lines inside sele
<under> – trim whitespace fro
```

tics

n

on

on
efinition

ent
e

nt node in syntax tree
ent node in syntax tree

or and cursor

rsor
direction (cursor at end)
ntax-aware

to cursor(s)

und / inside the object indicated by <ch>

RD

urround pairs
round pair

ss
parameter

hunk

d / WORD
ord / WORD

2.7 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
      y – selection -> yank buf
      p – paste yank buf after the cursor
      P – paste yank buf before the cursor
     ␣y – yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
     ␣Y – yank main selection -> system clipboard
  ␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / before selections(s)
     ␣R – replace selection(s) with clipboard
  r<ch> – replace selection with <ch>
      R – replace selection with yank buf
      " – select register to yank to or paste from
```

2.8 Search

```
  /<regex> – search forward for regex
  ?<regex> – search backward for regex
     n, N – next, previous match
        * – search for current selection, respect word boundaries
    Alt-* – search for current selection
```

2.9 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
   "<ch> – change to reg <ch>
  "<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
  "<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
  "<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.10 Macros

```
  "<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
  "<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.11 Jumplists

```
  Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
  Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
  Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
     ␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.12 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
       mm – go to matching delim
  mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
  ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
  ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
  md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.13 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
      | – replace selection(s) with output
  Alt-| – ignore output
      ! – insert output before each selection(s)
  Alt-! – append output after each selection(s)
      $ – keep selection(s) where command returned 0
```

2.14 Approaching an IDE

word / WORD
by line

ls

parent syntax node
bject selection
ng node in syntax tree
ode in syntax tree
les in syntax tree
odes in syntax tree

e (find)
e (till)
/ till

ion forward
ion backward
ection

is *primary*.

ections

above

rsor

selections
rimary selection
ection
wards / forwards
ward / forward
ching the regex
natching the regex

below cursor

`␣d` – debug - experimental
`␣k` – show documentation for item under cursor
`␣s` – open document symbol picker
`␣S` – open workspace symbol picker
`␣d` – open document diagnostics picker
`␣D` – open workspace diagnostics picker
`␣r` – rename symbol
`␣a` – apply code action
`␣h` – select symbol references for symbol under cursor

2.15 Editor Configuration

`:config-open` – open the config file
`:config-open-workspace` – open the workspace config file
`:config-reload` – reload the config file

2.16 Miscellaneous

`␣'` – open last picker
`␣/` – open global search in workspace folder picker

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

`Ctrl-s` – commit undo checkpoint
`Ctrl-x` – autocomplete
`Ctrl-r` – insert a register content
`Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp>` – delete previous word
`Alt-d, Alt-<del>` – delete next word
`Ctrl-u` – delete to start of line
`Ctrl-k` – delete to end of line
`Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp>` – delete previous char
`Ctrl-d, <del>` – delete next char
`Ctrl-j, <enter>` – insert new line
`<Up> <Down> <Left> <Right> <PageUp> <PageDown> <Home> <End>` – usual meaning but discouraged

3.2 Command Line Editing

`Esc, Ctrl-c` – close prompt
`<enter>` – open selected
`<tab>` – select next completion item
`<backtab>` – select previous completion item
`Alt-b` – backward a word
`Ctrl-b` – backward a char
`Alt-f` – forward a word
`Ctrl-f` – forward a char
`Ctrl-e` – to prompt end
`Ctrl-a` – to prompt start
`Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp>` – delete previous word
`Alt-d, Ctrl-<del>` – delete next word
`Ctrl-u` – delete to start of line
`Ctrl-k` – delete to end of line
`<bksp>, Ctrl-h` – delete previous char
`<del>, Ctrl-d` – delete next char
`Ctrl-s` – insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
`Ctrl-p` – select previous history
`Ctrl-n` – select next history
`Ctrl-r` – insert the content of the register selected by following input char

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

`Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up>` – previous entry
`<tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down>` – next entry
`<Home>` – to first entry
`<End>` – to last entry

```
bove cursor
normal)
```

```
nd selection
```

```
f, delete selection

ound selection
```

```
f, change selection

with <ch2>
```

```
ning selection
ining selection
```

```

```

```
ent
t
```

```
ted number
ted number
```

```
on
ction and select the inserted space
m selection
```

```
Ctrl-u, <PageUp> – page up
Ctrl-d, <PageDown> – page down
<enter> – open selected
Alt-<enter> – open selected in the background without
closing the picker
Ctrl-s – open horizontally
Ctrl-v – open vertically
Ctrl-t – toggle preview
Esc, Ctrl-c – close picker
```

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

```
Ctrl-u – scroll up
Ctrl-d – scroll down
```

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

```
Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p – previous entry
Tab, Ctrl-n – next entry
<enter> – close menu and accept completion
Ctrl-c – close menu and reject completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
Alt-p – previous signature
Alt-n – next signature
```